IFS-INFORMED COACHING · PARTS MAPPING

HIGH SIGNAL LLC

Who's Driving?
A Founder's Parts Mapping Starter

A 15-minute self-inventory to identify which internal parts are running your decisions right now — and negotiate one concrete agreement with each.

15 min

How to use this: Pick one current situation where you feel stuck, reactive, or avoidant. Work through all sections with that situation in mind. This is an operational self-awareness tool — not therapy. If something feels activating, slow down and come back to it.

→ The Situation

Name the specific thing. Not "work stress" — the actual decision, task, or interaction.

WHAT AM I STUCK ON / AVOIDING / REACTING TO RIGHT NOW?

Be specific — e.g. 'Sending the pricing proposal to the Series A lead'

HOW LONG HAS THIS BEEN SITTING?

e.g. 3 weeks

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN I THINK ABOUT DOING IT?

e.g. I open a new tab, feel dread

1 The Body Check-In

Parts show up in the body before the mind names them. Notice first.

🫁

Breath

shallow / held / fast

where do you feel it?

⚡

Tension / Energy

tight / buzzing / heavy

where in the body?

🌡️

Temperature / Sensation

hot / cold / numb

chest / gut / throat?

> You don't need to "figure out" what the sensations mean right now. Just noticing them creates a small amount of separation from the part — that separation is what we're after.

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2 Your Manager

The part running proactive protection — planning, controlling, perfecting, overworking.

The Manager Part

PROACTIVE PROTECTOR

*Managers work to prevent pain before it happens. Common founder Managers: The **Inner Critic** (attacks before anyone else can), The **Perfectionist** (nothing ships until it's flawless), The **Controller** (micromanages delegation to prevent being let down), The **Taskmaster** (overschedules to prove worth), The **Overcommitter** (says yes to everything; can't calibrate capacity), The **Image Manager** (tracks how you're perceived in every interaction).*

NAME THIS PART

e.g. The Perfectionist

WHAT IT'S DOING RIGHT NOW

e.g. insisting the proposal isn't ready

WHAT IT'S PROTECTING AGAINST

e.g. looking incompetent to the investor

HOW LONG IT'S BEEN DOING THIS

e.g. since my first failed pitch

MICRO-AGREEMENT WITH THIS MANAGER

What's the 'good enough' threshold? e.g. 3 non-negotiable criteria, then it ships

Specific next action + time: e.g. Send draft at 2pm today, imperfect and on purpose

3 Your Firefighter

The part that responds when activation is too high — distraction, avoidance, escape.

The Firefighter Part

REACTIVE PROTECTOR

*Firefighters respond to emotional overwhelm in the moment. Common founder Firefighters: The **Procrastinator** (new browser tab, new side project, anything but the hard thing), The **Shiny Object Part** (pivots to a new idea the moment this one gets hard), The **Doomscroller** (reaches for phone or news the moment activation rises), The **Explosive Part** (blows up the situation before it can hurt you), The **Workaholic** (hyperfocuses on low-stakes tasks to avoid the real one).*

NAME THIS PART

e.g. The Tab-Opener

WHAT IT DOES WHEN ACTIVATED

e.g. opens Slack, starts a new doc

WHAT FEELING IT'S EXTINGUISHING

e.g. the dread of being rejected

ITS EARLY WARNING SIGNAL

e.g. I start checking email every 4 minutes

MICRO-AGREEMENT WITH THIS FIREFIGHTER

Acknowledge what it's protecting: e.g. 'I see you. The rejection fear is real.'

Offer a safer exit: e.g. 5 min walk before opening proposal, then start

4 The Exile (Optional — go slowly here)

The feeling the Manager and Firefighter are both protecting. Name it — don't go into it.

What They're Guarding

UNDERLYING FEELING

You don't need to process this feeling today — that's therapy work. The coaching goal is simply to name it, acknowledge it, and let your protectors know you've seen it. That alone reduces their urgency.

IF I DO THIS THING AND IT GOES BADLY, I'D FEEL...

e.g. exposed as a fraud (Ashamed Part), r

THIS FEAR HAS BEEN WITH ME SINCE...

e.g. the first time a boss dismissed my ide

WHAT I'D WANT THIS PART TO KNOW

e.g. 'That was then. I have more resources now.'

⚖️ A note on where this ends

If completing this section brings up strong emotion, that's information — not a problem. In coaching, we notice that and slow down. Deep processing of exile material is therapy work. If you find yourself returning to this feeling repeatedly, that's worth exploring with a licensed therapist. Matt maintains a referral network for clinical support.

5 The Self Check

Self isn't a part. It's the capacity that's available when parts aren't overwhelming the system.

Accessing Self-Energy

THE 8 C'S

Curiosity · Calm · Clarity · Confidence · Courage · Compassion · Creativity · Connectedness. You don't need all eight. Even one is enough to make a decision from. Note: Self-energy doesn't always look like stillness — for neurodivergent founders it may show up as flow, deep focus, or playfulness.

RIGHT NOW I HAVE ACCESS TO	WHAT SELF WOULD SAY ABOUT THIS SITUATION	THE NEXT SMALLEST ACTION FROM SELF
e.g. Curiosity, Calm	e.g. 'It doesn't have to be p	e.g. Open the doc. Just op

✓ The One Commitment

One action. Specific. Time-stamped. Imperfect on purpose.

I WILL

the specific action...

AT EXACTLY

day + time — e.g. Today at 2:00pm

High Signal LLC

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